



FORTUNA ADMISSIONS
INSIDER'S TOP TIPS
FOR APPLYING TO
NORTHWESTERN KELLOGG

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ABOUT THE SCHOOL

The Kellogg School of Management is part of Northwestern University, located in Evanston about 12 miles north of downtown Chicago. The beautiful lakeside location in a thriving student town is a big part of the Kellogg culture, with time to cultivate strong ties with classmates that is so much part of the school's close-knit community. The collaborative learning style of the MBA program reinforces these ties, with a heavy emphasis on teamwork – 'we' rather than 'I.'

Stereo-typed as the school for marketing, Kellogg is in fact so much more. Energized by the arrival of Dean Sally Blount, the school looks for strong quant skills to underpin sharp analytical skills. So why does McKinsey recruit more Kellogg MBAs than any other U.S. school? Because they have humility, great analytical skills, and the people skills that mean they can be client facing from day one.

STRENGTHS AND SPECIALIZATIONS

Marketing, general management, non-profit/social responsibility, production/operations, strategy, entrepreneurship, healthcare, consumer goods

INCOMING CLASS

Number of Applicants: 4,595 MBA Class Size: 478
Admissions Selectivity: 20.7% Yield: 50.25%
Total Tuition: \$143,088

POST-MBA CAREERS

Sector: Consulting 30%; Technology 28%; Financial Services 14%; Consumer Products 7%
Top Recruiters: McKinsey, Bain, BCG, Deloitte Consulting
Avg. Base Salary: \$128,192 Employment in 3 months: 95%

MBA RANKINGS

	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018
BusinessWeek	5	5	7	3	9	9	8
Financial Times	9	8	9	8	11	12	8
Forbes	–	5	3	–	4	–	
The Economist	13	15	12	6	2	–	2
US News	4	4	6	6	5	4	6

ADMISSIONS

Avg. Age: 28 yrs Avg. GMAT: 732 Avg. GPA: 3.6
Int'l Students: 34% Female Students: 46%

Deadlines for 2018-2019: R1- Sep 18, '19 R2- Jan 8, '20 R3- Apr 8, '20

Sources: Northwestern Kellogg, BusinessWeek, Financial Times, US News, MBA50



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ESSAYS 2020

This year, Kellogg replaced its second required essay with the following:

Required essays:

1. Kellogg's purpose is to educate, equip & inspire brave leaders who create lasting value. Tell us about a time you have demonstrated leadership and created lasting value. What challenges did you face, and what did you learn? (450 words)
2. Values are what guide you in your life and work. What values are important to you and how have they influenced you? (450 words)

All applicants have the opportunity to provide explanations or clarification in **Additional Information**. Use this section if you think the person reviewing your application might have a few questions about one or more of your responses. This could include:

- Unexplained gaps in work experience
- Academic, GMAT or GRE performance
- Extenuating circumstances that we should be aware of when reviewing your application

VIDEO ESSAY:

Once you submit your application and payment, you'll have access to the video essay through your application status page. You'll then have 48 hours to complete the Video Essay after the application is due. Kellogg recommends you block out 20-25 minutes a few days after you submit your application and complete the video essay. This includes set-up time and answering the practice questions, though the official exercise takes only about 15 minutes.

You'll have an opportunity to get comfortable with the format by taking practice questions that simulate the actual experience – as many times as you like. However, you will not have the opportunity to re-do answers to your official questions. You are given 20 seconds to think about the question and up to one minute to give your response.

You will be asked to answer three questions:

Video essay 1: Please introduce yourself to the admissions committee.

Consider this your opportunity to share what you would want your future Kellogg classmates and our admissions committee to know about you. What makes you, you?

Video essay 2: What path are you interested in pursuing, how will you get there, and why is this program right for you?

This is an intentionally broad question so you can answer honestly and meaningfully. We want to know why you're pursuing an MBA and why you're choosing a particular Kellogg Full-Time Program.

Video essay 3: Each of you will receive a randomly selected prompt, all of which have the same objective. We want you to show us how you handled a challenging situation in your career or personal life. For example, we might ask you to tell us about a time you failed to achieve a goal you had set for yourself.



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Tip #1 - Play to your strengths . . . even if they seem conventional

Kellogg prides itself on building a truly diverse class across lots of dimensions. One of the signature traditions during orientation is for the Dean of Admissions to give a speech called "One of You" that runs down a list of remarkable highlights about new students. What this means for applicants is that there is a place for you based on your true, authentic self. In fact, officers take great pride in identifying candidates who have really self-reflected on what they want and how Kellogg will get them there. The key is to embrace your genuine story even if it seems entirely normal – failing to do so trips up more applicants than you can imagine. If you've taken a traditional path in banking because that's your interest, then own that. After all, an entire class can't be filled by Peace Corps workers who started their own microfinance funds and sing professionally on the side. And if you try to spice up your application with details or stories that read falsely, officers will sniff them out immediately.

Tip #2 - Differentiate yourself based on your conventions

In fact, Kellogg has become so diverse that more conventional paths can stand out. This is particularly true if you're coming from finance with plans to potentially stay in that industry or make a pivot from, say, private equity to investment banking. There is concern in some quarters that the program has embraced the poets at the expense of the quants. While this reflects a shift amongst the applicant pool (and the broader decline of interest in finance as the prestige MBA path), the school is very much attuned to applicants with a linear story and exceptional quant skills.

Tip #3 - Recognize that culture really does matter – and know what that means

As the Kellogg culture has become more deeply ingrained, the need to preserve it has heightened. Officers feel a real sense of obligation to protect what makes the school unique. Almost every aspect of the application has some component geared toward understanding if a student is the right fit. So what exactly does this culture of collaboration entail? Dean Blount expresses it as impact without ego, and that's about as good a definition as exists. Another way to think about the culture is like this: the program will force you to work in team settings constantly. Most people can be dependable peers for an hour at a time. But what if you're in hour 12 of an intense case analysis? Do you still have the maturity to be just as diplomatic as in hour 1? Or, if the problem with coming to an answer is that everyone in the group wants to be the leader, do you have the poise to switch roles and become the facilitator needed to get everyone on the same page? A strong applicant will show strong situational awareness and examples of how they can work in lots of different types of teams.

Tip #4 - Remember that culture isn't a synonym for fun

The most obvious part of the Kellogg culture from the moment you set foot on campus is the collegiality amongst the students. The mistake many applicants make is to treat those as the same or comprehensive of the total experience. Kellogg's social scene is definitely a big part of its appeal, but the culture runs much deeper than that and of course it's still a lot of hard work. Many applicants trip up by anchoring too heavily on their intended extracurricular involvement or even touching on their intentions to partake in the party scene. Even if your friends at Kellogg want to focus on how they're having the time of their lives and take you out the night before your interview, officers are looking for evidence of maturity and want to make sure you know you're prepared to put in a lot of effort. Personality matters, but so does professionalism. After all, if you're admitted in just a few short months you'll be conducting a similar interview for jobs – and representing the brand.



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Tip #5 - Don't let the marketing reputation fool you

Kellogg is one of the more diversified MBA programs. While the school is famous for marketing, the reality is that it sends the largest number of its students to consulting. The mix of the general management curriculum and highly specialized concentrations, plus the innovation and teamwork training, create a natural pipeline for top shops like McKinsey. But of course those skills speak to just about every industry and function. In fact, just to build on the fact that conventional profiles can actually stand out, job opportunities in finance are plentiful at the school. There's quite frankly less competition for those positions than at Wharton or Booth, and the same companies hire. There have been whispers in recent years of recruiters from financial institutions getting frustrated at not filling all their quotas from Kellogg.

Tip #6 - Tell a good story

This doesn't mean embellish. Quite the opposite, the advice here is to aim for consistency in putting together your application with clear threads throughout. Since Kellogg prides itself on providing a transformative and aspirational experience, candidates can easily go off the rails. You definitely want to aim high, but make sure the supporting elements are solid. Do your essays and letters of recommendation define a similar vision? Do your letters of recommendation and interview paint a similar portrait? Do your undergrad experiences line up with your essays? Candidates can sometimes get a little carried away, which leads to big dreams that don't seem based in any previous experiences.

Tip #7 - Have a viable alternative

Perhaps the most oft-cited critique or question from a Kellogg officer: "does this person have a plan b?" That's another way of saying that the story didn't quite come together and that the ending in particular is concerning. In the high-stakes rankings game, Kellogg has done well in large part with the employment record of a large percentage of its graduates. The careers staff do a phenomenal job in working with students, but they also don't want to have to take unnecessary risks. To tie this all together with the other tips, if your plan is to start your own company but you have no entrepreneurship anywhere in your background and your recommenders say you're risk-averse, you need to display a viable alternative. And at a school in which competition for a position in consulting is fierce, working for Bain, BCG or McKinsey in order to "round out your experiences and get exposed to lots of different industries" is not a solid backup.

More about Fortuna Admissions:

Fortuna Admissions is a dream team of former MBA Admissions Directors and Officers from the top-tier business schools, including Wharton, INSEAD, Harvard Business School, Stanford GSB, Kellogg, LBS, Chicago Booth, Columbia, NYU Stern, IE, Duke Fuqua, UCLA Anderson, Cornell Johnson and Berkeley Haas.

As industry experts, we regularly provide commentary and analysis about b-school admissions for major media around the world. To read our full range of advice visit: FortunaAdmissions.com

With our unparalleled collective expertise, we are able to coach you to develop a clear vision of your goals for business school and beyond. We work closely with you throughout the application process and provide expert guidance at every stage to maximize your chances of admission to a top school.

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